

Papal Supremacy Denial

doc-papal-supremacy-denial
Leadership & Polity · Ordination · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

No human bishop or council possesses supreme authority over the universal Church; no human teacher pronounces with the infallibility that belongs to Scripture alone as the rule of faith and life.

In plain language

The words here weigh whether the texts give one human leader a supreme, error-free authority over the whole church that they reserve for God and his written word. The pivotal verse is Matthew 16:18, 'You are Peter, and on this rock I will build my church'. In the Greek the name addressed to the apostle is masculine, 'Peter' (Πέτρος, Petros), which the lexicon calls 'a detached stone', while the rock that is built on is feminine, 'rock' (πέτρα, petra), which the lexicon calls 'a mass of solid bedrock', and the words 'this' and 'the' go with the feminine 'rock', not with Peter's name. So the two forms differ in both gender and sense. Even so, the rock can still be read as Peter himself, because a rock metaphor naturally takes the feminine word and Peter's Aramaic name carried no gender, which is why this stays genuinely open. The keys and the power to 'bind' (δέω, deō) and 'loose' (λύω, lyō) are given to Peter alone in Matthew 16:19, where 'you bind' is singular, yet the very same power is given to all the disciples together in Matthew 18:18, where 'you bind' is plural, and the same word for 'key' names 'the key of knowledge' in Luke 11:52. In John 21 Jesus tells Peter to 'feed' (βόσκει, boske) and 'shepherd' (ποιμαίνει, poimaine) the sheep, which is pastoral care language, not the language of ruling over others. Elsewhere Peter is openly corrected by Paul ('I withstood', ἀντέστην, antestēn), is questioned by the Jerusalem believers, is one of three 'pillars' (στυλοί, styloi) alongside James and John, and calls himself a 'fellow elder' (συμπρεσβύτερος, sympresbyteros). The foundation of the church is named as the apostles together in Ephesians 2:20 and as the twelve in Revelation 21:14, with Christ the one foundation in 1 Corinthians 3:11. All of this leans against a single supreme office. The reason this is recorded as contested rather than settled is that Peter is named 'first' (πρῶτος, prōtos) in the apostle list in Matthew 10:2, the rock saying can be read of Peter, and crucially no word anywhere names Rome, a successor, or a power passed on, so the very thing the proposition denies is left undefined by the words themselves.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0436	ἀντίστημι	anthistēmi	to oppose	14
G1006	βόσκω	boskō	to feed	9
G1124	γραφή	graphē	a writing	51
G1210	δέω	deō	to bind	154
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	114

G2310	θεμέλιος	themelios	foundation	15
G2786	Κηφᾶς	Kēphas	Cephas	9
G2807	κλείς	kleis	key	6
G3089	λύω	lyō	to loose	42
G3618	οικοδομέω	oikodomeō	to build	40
G4073	πέτρα	petra	rock	15
G4074	Πέτρος	Petros	Peter	156
G4165	ποιμαίνω	poimainō	to shepherd	11
G4413	πρῶτος	prōtos	first	153

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The word-level data leans toward the denial of a transferable supreme Petrine (relating to the apostle Peter) office but cannot close the question. In Matthew 16:18 the form addressed to the apostle is the masculine word 'Peter' (Πέτρος, Petros, G4074), which the lexicon glosses as 'a detached stone', while the foundation is the feminine word 'rock' (πέτρα, petra, G4073), glossed as 'a mass of live rock as distinct from a detached stone (πέτρος)', and the demonstrative 'this' (ταύτη, tautē) and the article 'the' (τῇ, tē) are feminine, agreeing with the feminine 'rock' (πέτρα, petra). The same keys and 'binding' (δήσης, dēsēs, 2nd person singular, 'you-singular bind') and 'loosing' (λύσης, lysēs, 2nd person singular, 'you-singular loose') given to Peter in the singular in Matthew 16:19 are given to the disciples in the plural ('you-all bind', δήσητε, dēsēte, 2nd person plural; 'you-all loose', λύσητε, lysēte, 2nd person plural) in Matthew 18:18, and John 21:15-17 gives Peter a pastoral 'feed' (βόσκει, boske) and 'shepherd' (ποιμαίνε, poimaine) charge, not a jurisdictional (ruling-office) grant. Peter is opposed by Paul ('I withstood', ἀντέστην, antestēn, a completed past action, Galatians 2:11), questioned at Jerusalem ('they took issue', διεκρίνοντο, diekrinonto, ongoing or repeated past action, Acts 11:2), and is one of three 'pillars' (στυλοί, styloi, Galatians 2:9) and a 'fellow elder' (συμπρεσβύτερος, sympresbyteros, 1 Peter 5:1), while the foundation is the apostles plural (Ephesians 2:20, Revelation 21:14) on Christ the only foundation (1 Corinthians 3:11). It stays disputed because 'rock' (πέτρα, petra) can defensibly be construed as Peter personally, Peter is named 'first' (πρῶτος, prōtos) in the list (Matthew 10:2), and the vocabulary simply does not name Rome, a successor, or an error-free office, so the SCOPE the proposition denies is underdetermined by the words.

Scripture

Matt.16.18 · complicates · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4074 Πέτρος, G4073 πέτρα, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. 'You are Peter, and on this rock I will build my assembly or church' (σὺ εἶ Πέτρος, καὶ ἐπὶ ταύτῃ τῇ πέτρᾳ οἰκοδομήσω μου τὴν ἐκκλησίαν; ekklēsia carries the polysemous sense 'assembly or church'). The morphology (grammatical form of the words) shows 'Peter' (Πέτρος, Petros) as nominative singular masculine (the subject form, singular, masculine gender) and 'rock' (πέτρα, petra) as dative singular feminine (the 'to/in/on-X' form, singular, feminine gender), with the demonstrative 'this' (ταύτη, tautē) and the article 'the' (τῇ, tē) also feminine and agreeing with the feminine 'rock' (πέτρα, petra), not with the masculine 'Peter' (Πέτρος, Petros). The lexicon glosses 'Peter' (Πέτρος, Petros) as 'a detached stone' and 'rock' (πέτρα, petra) as 'a mass of live rock as distinct from a detached stone (πέτρος, petros)', so the two forms differ in gender and in attested sense. The text addresses the apostle by name and builds on the rock, but the Greek does not by itself fix whether the rock is Peter, his confession, or Christ, and it says nothing of a successor or of Rome.

Matt.16.19 · complicates · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2807 κλείς, G1210 δέω, G3089 λύω

Reasoning. 'I will give to you the keys of the kingdom of the heavens, and whatever you bind' (δώσω σοι τὰς κλεῖδας τῆς βασιλείας τῶν οὐρανῶν, καὶ ὃ ἐὰν δήσῃς). The pronoun 'to you' (σοι, soi) and the verbs 'you bind' (δήσῃς, dēsēs) and 'you loose' (λύσῃς, lysēs) are second person singular (addressed to one person), addressed to Peter alone here. The same word 'key' (κλείς, kleis) is used elsewhere of 'the key of knowledge', Luke 11:52, so the keys image is not a technical term for a transferable office. The grant is real and singular in this verse, which a primacy (first-place authority) reading can lean on.

Matt.18.18 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1210 δέω, G3089 λύω

Reasoning. 'Whatever you-all bind on earth will be bound in heaven' (ὅσα ἐὰν δήσητε ἐπὶ τῆς γῆς ἔσται δεδεμένα ἐν οὐρανῷ). Here the pronoun 'to you-all' (ὕμῖν, hymin) and the verbs 'you-all bind' (δήσητε, dēsēte) and 'you-all loose' (λύσητε, lysēte) are second person plural (addressed to a group), addressed to the disciples as a body, and the bound and loosed participles 'having been bound' (δεδεμένα, dedemena) and 'having been loosed' (λελυμένα, lelymena) are neuter plural against the singular 'having been bound' (δεδεμένον, dedemenon) and 'having been loosed' (λελυμένον, lelymenon) of Matthew 16:19. The identical binding and loosing authority is therefore extended to the disciples plural, which weakens the idea that the Matthew 16:19 grant marks out a unique office reserved to Peter and his successors.

John.21.16 · for · genre: gospel · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G4165 ποιμαίνω, G1006 βόσκω

Reasoning. 'Shepherd my sheep' (Ποίμαινε τὰ πρόβατά μου, Poimaine ta probata mou), with 'Feed my lambs' (Βόσκε τὰ ἀρνία μου, Boske ta arnia mou) and 'Feed my sheep' (Βόσκε τὰ πρόβατά μου, Boske ta probata mou) in verses 15 and 17. The imperatives 'feed' (βόσκε, boske) and 'shepherd' (ποιμαίνε, poimaine) are second person singular present (a present-tense command to one person), a pastoral charge to feed and shepherd. The vocabulary is the language of caring for a flock, the same 'shepherd' (ποιμαίνω, poimainō) used of elders generally in Acts 20:28 and 1 Peter 5:2, not the language of jurisdiction (ruling authority) or supreme rule. The text commissions Peter to pastor, but does not lexically (at the word level) grant a governing primacy (top-rank ruling authority) over the whole church or over other apostles.

Matt.10.2 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4413 πρῶτος

Reasoning. 'First, Simon who is called Peter' (πρῶτος Σίμων ὁ λεγόμενος Πέτρος, prōtos Simōn ho legomenos Petros). The adjective 'first' (πρῶτος, prōtos) is nominative singular masculine (subject form, singular, masculine) and heads the list of the twelve apostles, naming Peter first. This is genuine textual prominence for Peter and is the lexical (word-level) footing for a primacy (first-place authority) reading. The word 'first' (πρῶτος, prōtos) denotes first in sequence or rank in a listing, but it is applied here within a list of equals called apostles, and the same word ranks many ordinary things elsewhere, so it establishes leadership and prominence without by itself establishing a supreme jurisdictional (top ruling) office.

Gal.2.9 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2786 Κηφᾶς

Reasoning. 'James and Cephas and John, who were reputed to be pillars' (Ἰάκωβος καὶ Κηφᾶς καὶ Ἰωάννης, οἱ δοκοῦντες στῦλοι εἶναι; 'Cephas' is the Aramaic name for Peter, Κηφᾶς, Kēphas). The noun 'pillars' (στῦλοι, styloi) is plural and names three men, with James listed first, so 'Cephas' (Κηφᾶς, Kēphas, that is, Peter) is one of several pillars rather than a single supreme head. The collegial (shared-leadership) plural here sits against a doctrine of one unaccountable supreme bishop.

Gal.2.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2786 Κηφᾶς, G0436 ἀντίστημι

Reasoning. 'I withstood him to his face because he stood condemned' (κατὰ πρόσωπον αὐτῷ ἀντέστην, ὅτι κατεγνωσμένος ἦν). Paul applies the verb 'I withstood' (ἀντέστην, antestēn, a completed past action) to 'Cephas' (Κηφᾶς, Kēphas, that is, Peter) and the perfect passive participle 'having been condemned' (κατεγνωσμένος, kategnōsmenos, a completed condition still standing, in the passive voice), naming Peter as already under condemnation. A peer apostle publicly opposes Peter, which cuts against Peter holding an office that no one may correct.

Acts.11.2 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4074 Πέτρος

Reasoning. 'Those of the circumcision took issue with him' (διεκρίνοντο πρὸς αὐτὸν οἱ ἐκ περιτομῆς). The verb 'they were taking issue' (διεκρίνοντο, diekrinonto, ongoing or repeated past action) has the Jerusalem believers contending with 'Peter' (Πέτρος, Petros) when he returns, and Peter then lays out his account in order, 'he was setting forth in order' (ἐξετίθετο καθεξῆς, exetitheto kathexēs) in verse 4, before the matter is settled. Peter is held to account by the assembly, which fits a peer answerable to the body rather than a supreme head above question.

Eph.2.20 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος

Reasoning. 'Built upon the foundation of the apostles and prophets' (ἐποικοδομηθέντες ἐπὶ τῷ θεμελίῳ τῶν ἀποστόλων καὶ προφητῶν), with Christ Jesus as the 'cornerstone' (ἀκρογωνιαίου, akrogōniaiou). The genitive (of-form) 'of the apostles' (τῶν ἀποστόλων, tōn apostolōn) is plural, so the church is founded on the apostles as a group, not on one apostle, and the cornerstone is Christ. This locates the 'foundation' (θεμέλιος, themelios) in a plurality, not in a single Petrine (Peter-related) office.

Rev.21.14 · for · genre: apocalyptic · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος

Reasoning. 'Twelve foundations, and on them twelve names of the twelve apostles' (θεμελίους δώδεκα, καὶ ἐπ' αὐτῶν δώδεκα ὀνόματα τῶν δώδεκα ἀποστόλων). The noun 'foundations' (θεμελίους, themelious) is plural and is numbered twelve, distributing the foundation across all twelve apostles equally. No single name is elevated above the others on the wall of the city.

1Cor.3.11 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2310 θεμέλιος

Reasoning. 'No one can lay another foundation than the one laid, which is Jesus Christ' (θεμέλιον γὰρ ἄλλον οὐδεὶς δύναται θεῖναι παρὰ τὸν κείμενον, ὃς ἐστὶν Ἰησοῦς Χριστός). The singular 'foundation' (θεμέλιον, themelion) with 'no one' (οὐδεὶς, oudeis) and 'another' (ἄλλον, allon) excludes any rival foundation and identifies it as Christ. Read with Ephesians 2:20 and Revelation 21:14, the foundation language centers on Christ and the apostles plural, not on a single transferable Petrine (Peter-related) seat.

1Pet.5.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4074 Πέτρος

Reasoning. 'I exhort the elders among you as a fellow elder' (Πρεσβυτέρους οὖν ἐν ὑμῖν παρακαλῶ ὁ συμπρεσβύτερος). Peter styles himself 'the fellow elder' (ὁ συμπρεσβύτερος, ho sympresbyteros), where the 'with/together' prefix (συν, syn) places him alongside the elders he exhorts rather than above them. This self-description in collegial parity (shared, equal-rank standing) weighs against a claim that Peter held a unique supreme rank over the universal church.

Acts.17.11 · **for** · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1124 γραφή

Reasoning. 'Examining the Scriptures daily whether these things were so' (ἀνακρίνοντες τὰς γραφὰς εἰ ἔχου ταῦτα οὕτως). The Bereans are called more noble for testing even apostolic preaching against 'the Scriptures' (τὰς γραφὰς, *tas graphas*), placing final verification in the written word rather than in the standing of the speaker, which bears on the second clause of the proposition about the rule of faith.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Gal.2.14	Gal.2.11	tsk	1
Acts.17.11	Ps.1.2	tsk	1
2Tim.3.16	Ps.19.7	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Matt.16.18 · **addressed**

'You are Peter, and on this rock I will build my assembly or church' (σὺ εἶ Πέτρος, καὶ ἐπὶ ταύτῃ τῇ πέτρᾳ οἰκοδομήσω μου τὴν ἐκκλησίαν; *ekklēsia* carries the polysemous sense 'assembly or church'). The morphology (grammatical form of the words) gives masculine 'Peter' (Πέτρος, *Petros*, G4074, nominative singular masculine, that is, subject-form singular masculine, glossed 'a detached stone') and feminine 'rock' (πέτρα, *petra*, G4073, dative singular feminine, that is, 'to/in/on-X' form singular feminine, glossed 'a mass of live rock as distinct from a detached stone (πέτρος, *petros*)'), with the feminine demonstrative 'this' (ταύτῃ, *tautē*) and the feminine article 'the' (τῇ, *tē*) agreeing with the feminine 'rock' (πέτρα, *petra*). The gender and sense distinction is real, yet a defensible construal still reads 'rock' (πέτρα, *petra*) as Peter himself, since the underlying Aramaic name would not mark gender and a feminine noun is the natural form for the metaphor of the rock. This is genuinely open at the word level. It is addressed by noting that even on the personal reading the verse grants no transferable office and names no successor or Rome, but because the construal is not forced one way, the proposition cannot be lexically (at the word level) closed and is recorded as disputed.

Matt.16.19 · **addressed**

'I will give to you the keys ... whatever you bind' (δώσω σοι τὰς κλεῖδας ... ὃ ἐὰν δήσῃς). The keys and the 'binding' (δέω, *deō*) and 'loosing' (λύω, *lyō*) are given to Peter in the second person singular (addressed to one person), which a primacy (first-place authority) reading takes as a personal commission. This is addressed by the parallel in Matthew 18:18, where the same 'bind' (δέω, *deō*) and 'loose' (λύω, *lyō*) are second person plural (addressed to a group) to the disciples as a body, and by Luke 11:52 where the same word 'key' (κλεῖς, *kleis*) names the key of knowledge, showing the image is not a technical term for a unique transferable seat. The singular grant is real but the canon supplies a matching plural grant the words do not rank above it.

Matt.10.2 · **addressed**

'First, Simon' (πρῶτος Σίμων, *prōtos Simōn*). Peter is named first in the apostle list, and parallel narratives show him leading and speaking first in Acts 1 to 5. This prominence is genuine and is the strongest lexical (word-level) footing for a primacy (first-place authority) reading. It is addressed by observing that 'first' (πρῶτος, *prōtos*) here orders a list of men all called apostles, and that prominence, leadership, and being named first are not the same as a supreme jurisdictional (top ruling) office that the vocabulary nowhere defines, transfers, or attaches to a see (a bishop's official seat). The word establishes that Peter is foremost, not that a supreme office exists or passes on.

Concordance traversed

G4074, G4073, G2786, G1210, G3089, G2807, G4413, G2310, G4165, G1006, G0436, G1577, G3618, G1124

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No CBGM (Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, a method for tracing textual relationships) apparatus covers the anchor verses. The only ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) variant units are for 3 John, outside this question's scope, so the 'not in ECM scope' status holds. The Matthew 16, Matthew 18, John 21, and Galatians 2 readings carry SBLGNT (Society of Biblical Literature Greek New Testament) editorial sigla (editorial marks), for example the spelling of 'Cephas' (Κηφᾶς, Kēphas) and 'Peter' (Πέτρος, Petros) in Galatians 2 and minor placement of 'if/whenever' (ἐάν, ean), but none of these touch the masculine 'Peter' (Πέτρος, Petros) versus feminine 'rock' (πέτρα, petra) distinction, the singular versus plural 'binding' (δέω, deō) and 'loosing' (λύω, lyō), or the pastoral 'feed' (βόσκει, boske) and 'shepherd' (ποιμαίνει, poimaine) charge, so the verdict holds across plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. petrine_primacy, apostolic_collegiality

analogia scripturae invoked

petrine_primacy: complicates · On its strongest lexical (word-level) form this lens reads 'rock' (πέτρα, petra) in Matthew 16:18 as Peter himself, since the metaphor of a rock naturally takes the feminine noun and the underlying Aramaic name marks no gender, so the wordplay 'You are Peter, and on this rock' (σύ εἶ Πέτρος, ἐπὶ ταύτῃ τῇ πέτρᾳ, sy ei Petros, epi tautē tē petra) identifies the man as the rock on which the church is built. It adds that the keys and 'binding' (δέω, deō) and 'loosing' (λύω, lyō) are given to Peter in the singular in Matthew 16:19, that John 21:15-17 singles Peter out for the 'feed' (βόσκει, boske) and 'shepherd' (ποιμαίνει, poimaine) charge, and that Peter is named 'first' (πρῶτος, prōtos) in Matthew 10:2 and leads throughout Acts 1 to 5. On this reading the texts assign Peter a real personal primacy (first-place authority) among the apostles, and the words leave room to extend that prominence into an enduring office.

apostolic_collegiality: supports · On its strongest lexical (word-level) form this lens notes that 'Peter' (Πέτρος, Petros) is masculine and lexically 'a detached stone' while the foundation 'rock' (πέτρα, petra) is feminine and lexically 'a mass of live rock', that the identical 'binding' (δέω, deō) and 'loosing' (λύω, lyō) of Matthew 16:19 is given to the disciples plural in Matthew 18:18, and that the 'foundation' (θεμέλιος, themelios) is the apostles plural in Ephesians 2:20 and the twelve in Revelation 21:14 on Christ the only foundation in 1 Corinthians 3:11. It adds that Peter is opposed by Paul in Galatians 2:11, questioned at Jerusalem in Acts 11:2, listed as one of three 'pillars' (στυλοὶ, styloi) in Galatians 2:9, and calls himself a 'fellow elder' (συμπρεσβύτερος, sympresbyteros) in 1 Peter 5:1. On this reading the apostles function as an accountable college and no word grants a single bishop a supreme transferable office or names a successor or Rome.

Both lenses are grammatically available on the anchor texts, which is why the verdict is disputed rather than a clean affirmation. The collegial (shared-leadership) reading has the wider canon spread and the gender and sense distinction of 'Peter' (Πέτρος, Petros) versus 'rock' (πέτρα, petra) plus the plural 'binding' (δέω, deō) and 'loosing' (λύω, lyō) of Matthew 18:18 on its side; the primacy (first-place authority) reading has Peter's named prominence, the singular grant of Matthew 16:19, and the open construal of 'rock' (πέτρα, petra) on its side. The decisive point for the SUPREMACY claim specifically is that no vocabulary in either reading supplies succession, transfer of office, Rome, or an error-free human pronouncement, so the scope the proposition denies is underdetermined by the words.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. What teaching and governing authority, if any, do the texts assign to a single human leader or council over the whole church, whether such authority is unique to one figure or transferable to successors, and on what basis the rule of faith is identified.

The stem bundles two claims and frames both as denials: that no human bishop or council has supreme authority over the universal church, and that infallibility (the inability to err) belongs to Scripture alone as the rule of faith. The second clause presupposes a sola-scriptura (Scripture-alone) conclusion, and the first presupposes the denial of any supreme human office, so the proposition encodes its own answer. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form was used to test whether the lexical

(word-level) data independently warrants the denial of papal supremacy before scoring. The pan_canonical (spread across the whole Bible) flag was set to false in this pass because every anchor verse sits in the New Testament canon section; the lemmas (dictionary headword forms) spread widely across Gospels, Acts, the Pauline and general epistles, and the Apocalypse, but they do not span the Old and New Testaments or the law, prophets, and writings, so an honest reading is NT-internal breadth rather than pan-canonical (whole-Bible) spread.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.16.18
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.16.19
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.18.18
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.21.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Eph.2.20
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4074
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4073
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License audit

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lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent